



The United States

Even though India made concessions on big-ticket defence purchases, America fails to criticise Pakistan and hedges on nuclear deal commitments and climate change.

Yekaterinburg, telling him, "I am happy to meet you but my mandate is limited to telling you that the territory of Pakistan must not be allowed to be used for terrorism against India." By saying it loud enough for the TV cameras to pick up, he not only embarrassed Zardari but seemed to set the parameters for resuming a dialogue with Pakistan. Manmohan apologised later to Zardari and a month later at the Sharm el-Sheikh summit with Pakistan Prime Minister Yousaf Raza Gilani, he inexplicably bent backwards to be accommodative to Pakistan.

Manmohan seems to have been convinced by Gilani's promise that Pakistan would take all action to bring the perpetrators of the Mumbai attacks to book. The joint statement that was issued surprisingly delinked action on terror from the composite dialogue process which was a reversal of his earlier stand. It even went on to mention Pakistan's concern about India's interference in Balochistan. Experts saw the inclusion as blasphemous and called it a convenient stick for Islamabad to beat India with whenever it broached the issue of terror. When India's opposition parties protested vociferously and no support seemed forthcoming from his own party, Manmohan backtracked in

Parliament, clarifying that "the starting point of a meaningful dialogue" with Pakistan would be if it kept its commitment not to allow its territory to be used for terrorist activities against India. Former Indian high commissioner to Pakistan G. Parthasarathy says, "The prime minister has a confused perception of Pakistan. Some of his notions have no relation to reality. He keeps flip-flopping and our Pakistan policy is now in a mess."

Yet as is increasingly evident, it is not just in its dealings with Pakistan that the UPA Government is facing mounting flak for its flat-footedness and timidity. Lalit Mansingh, a former foreign secretary, says, "The prime minister does have a soaring vision about the role of India but there is a major dissonance when it comes to practice and getting it implemented." Take India's relations with the US. George Bush and Manmohan Singh were able to effect a sea change in relations between the two countries. But with a Democratic administration led by Barack Obama taking charge early this year, an element of uncertainty had crept in between the two countries. It didn't help that, while Obama was focused internally on the economy and externally on Iraq and

(ANTI-CLOCKWISE FROM TOP) MANMOHAN WITH HILLARY CLINTON AND HU JINTAO; VLADIMIR PUTIN